



Man of the moment: Yashasvi Jaiswal became the fastest Indian to reach 1000 runs as an opener in men's Tests, bettering the record held by captain Rohit Sharma. He was adjudged Man of the Series. **R.V. MOORTHY**

credible performances during the England Lions' tour of India, which ran parallel to the Test series. The only outlier was Rajat Patidar, who struck two hundreds against the Lions but couldn't find his feet at the top level.

India's heartening success with inexperience was pervasive. Yashasvi Jaiswal and Kuldeep Yadav, with a combined 12 Test caps ahead of the series, shouldered the bulk of the load. While Jaiswal broke a slew of records on his way to becoming only the second India to breach the 700-run mark in a single Test series and cemented the opener's slot, Kuldeep returned from the Test wilderness to vindicate the management's refreshing departure from its selection policy.

With Ravindra Jadeja injured following the first Test, India may have been tempted to draft in all-rounder Washington Sundar but instead opted for Kuldeep's superior skills with the ball. The result was a

19-wicket haul at a miserly average of 20.15, significantly superior to that of Ravichandran Ashwin (24.8) and Jadeja (25.05).

Kuldeep is often the one to make way when the management wants to shoehorn in an extra batter or pacer. But when Kuldeep's spin trumped Axar Patel's prowess with the bat against spin in making way for Sarfaraz's debut, that policy turned a corner. He repaid the faith with the bat too, putting a premium on his wicket by facing 362 balls, significantly more than what Jonny Bairstow could manage (290).

The series also helped solidify India's top three. After a string of low scores since opting to drop down to No. 3 in the West Indies, Shubman Gill was under pressure before redeeming himself with two hundreds and a couple of gritty second-innings knocks to all but seal his spot. With skipper Rohit Sharma also among the runs, the top-order looks settled, but the return of Kohli and Rahul could ruffle some feathers in the middle-order when Bangladesh and New Zealand come touring. With India concluding its WTC cycle with a five-match showdown Down Under late in the year, the complexion of the middle-order could drastically change

with the conditions.

England, on the other hand, doesn't have the luxury of looking that far ahead. That it languishes in the eighth spot in the WTC standings after 10 matches against two of its most formidable opponents — Australia and India — should pose an existential question.

Following its shock win in the first Test in Hyderabad, which prompted India to prepare pitches on which batting isn't a lottery, it has been a campaign of 'what ifs' for England.

Perhaps it could have opted for a five-man bowling attack rather than saddling an under-fire Joe Root with 118 overs. What if Root hadn't been as besotted with his reverse scoop when England was on top in the first innings in Rajkot?

Perhaps a tweak in approach could have seen it over the line in a record chase on a benign Visakhapatnam wicket. Could Ben Stokes have done more with the ball than making a guest appearance on the penultimate day of the series?

The gospel of Bazball arrived with temptation but left Indian shores with a faint whisper: England registered the second-highest run rate (3.84) ever by a visiting side in India. A shade lower, India's 3.49 was more than a handful for it. To